

SOCIAL CLIMATE

What are you looking for? For one thing, you want a good social climate. Primary education is partly a process of learning to deal with peers. You want Johnny to grow up with kids who behave well, respect private property, and share. Those kids should have a sense of responsibility and persistence. They should enjoy life and be decent people. You'd like Johnny to avoid growing up with youngsters who settle schoolyard disputes by hauling out hand-held rocket launchers.

Perhaps the biggest advantage of a small-town public school in the South is that Johnny can spend his early years in a relaxed, easygoing social climate. He'll live without the stress, competition, and fear that can terrify a child in Chicago or Seattle—not to mention New York City.

"There's a nervous tension you have to live with," teacher Barbara Statlow told *The New York Times* in a 1980 interview. "It's exhausting." Mrs. Statlow teaches at Thomas Jefferson High in the Brownsville section of Brooklyn. When she says there's nervous tension, she's not talking about discipline problems. She's talking about crime. According to the article, "Crime against New York City's public school teachers has become so common that, for many of them, its existence no longer shocks." Officials talk about security at Jefferson High the way a warden might talk about a federal penitentiary. Double- and triple-locked steel doors protect classrooms. Guards patrol the halls, bathrooms, and gyms. Yet, teachers and students alike worry about being robbed, slapped around, beaten, knifed, raped, or murdered.

Fortunately, you can largely forget about serious crime in small towns in Kentucky or Georgia. But beyond crime, how can you make sure your children are exposed to the right social climate at school? One way is to talk to other parents. Ask them why Billy likes math, Sally the playground, Tommy his fifth-grade teacher. Ask local merchants, bankers, librarians, and travel agents what they think of the local schools. They'll introduce you to others who can give you more input.